SPECIAL TIME

What is Special Time?

5-10 minutes per day giving your full, undivided attention to one child

Child leads play/activity and parent uses specific strategies to show that they are engaged and following their child's lead

WHY DO SPECIAL TIME?

Makes your child feel loved and special

Powerful way to fill their "emotional cup" with positive attention

Strengthens your relationship to be more resilient to challenges

Uses the power of your attention to encourage positive interactions

Over time, decreases other behavioral challenges throughout the day

HOW TO DO SPECIAL TIME

- Protect 5-10 minutes per day with one child
  - Be consistent and don't take it away as a punishment
- Let your child pick which activity to do together
  - Can either call it "special time" or build it into your daily routine without labeling it as a special activity
- Use PRIDE skills (see below)
- Avoid criticism, commands, and questions (see below)
- End special time early if your child engages in dangerous or destructive behavior





MASSACHUSETTS GENERAL HOSPITAL

YOUNG CHILD PARENTING GROUP AT MGH

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SPECIAL TIME

PRIDE SKILLS

Praise
Give specific praise for positive behaviors
→ Tells them exactly which behaviors you like and increases positive interactions
"Thank you for giving me a Lego"

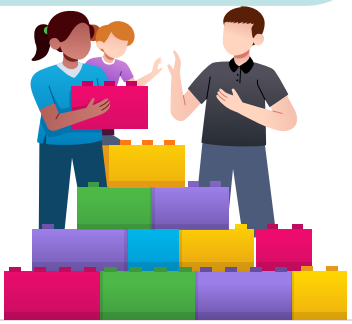
Reflect
Say what they say
→ Shows your child that you are listening without making additional demands (like questions or suggesting next steps for play)
"Yes, you're making a castle."

Imitate
Do what they do
→ Shows that you are paying attention and like their behavior
If your child is building with Legos, you build with Legos too.

Describe
Say what they do
→ Shows that you are paying attention and following their lead
"You're building a tower on the front side of the castle"

Enjoy
Relax and have fun with your child
→ Builds positive experiences together and strengthens the relationship
Laugh and smile with them





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SPECIAL TIME

BEHAVIORS TO AVOID

Criticism and Sarcasm (no, don't stop, quit)

- Gives attention to behaviors you want to decrease, can lead to escalating negative interactions, decreases enjoyment
- Instead, focus on the opposite good behavior ("nice job taking apart the Legos gently")

Commands (do this, not that)

- Increases likelihood of negative interactions and conflict
- Instead, say "Hmm, I wonder what will happen if you do that? Let's see"

Questions (what are you building now?)

- Focuses on quizzing/teaching rather than interacting, can communicate disapproval or that a parent is not listening
- Instead, say "I wonder what you're creating, I'm excited to see the next steps"





Dangerous and Destructive Behaviors

Warn your child once that these behaviors (hitting, breaking toys, etc) will result in special time ending early today. If they do the behavior a second time, end special time immediately (walking out of the room is one way to do so).

During special time the next day, focus on giving positive attention for safe behaviors (gentle hands, gently using toys) to further encourage these behaviors.

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